



MONTHLY UPDATE

Malawi: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-18 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY
· CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Two systems went the wrong way and one was made more resilient. The farm input subsidy programme [reverted to manual coupons for 2026-27](#), a [return technologists questioned before the September rollout](#) — this ledger's clearest case of a digitised process being undone — and the state oil company [confirmed the loss of K700m to payment fraud](#). Against them, the revenue authority's [secondary data centre is reported improving service continuity at border posts and the international airport](#).

The measurements were the month's more useful half. An industry association [put 80% of the population offline against 87% 4G population coverage](#) — a usage gap rather than a coverage one — while the statistics office and the regulator [opened enumerator training for a fourth national ICT survey covering 12,000 households](#). Parliament [passed the Financial Crimes \(Amendment\) Bill](#), which awaits assent, and the minister [stated an intention to legislate on artificial intelligence](#).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The draft national artificial intelligence strategy the UNESCO readiness assessment is intended to guide remains pre-adoption.

The revenue authority launched a five-year Corporate Strategic Plan in Blantyre on 24 August, [resting on a wider tax base, digitisation and evidence-based research and targeting a rise in the tax-to-GDP ratio from 16 per cent towards 20 per cent by 2031](#), the finance minister framing domestic taxation as the route left by falling donor support and shrinking customs revenue.

Legislation and regulation

Two instruments, one passed and one only intended. Parliament [passed the Financial Crimes \(Amendment\) Bill in the week to 6 August](#), which awaits assent; the bill text is not held, so what it changes for digital finance cannot be read off the record. Separately the minister [stated an intention to legislate on artificial intelligence](#), with no draft, scope or timetable behind the statement.

Data protection

A gap the repository has carried since April closed this month, though not by the route that would have settled it. The United States embassy [said Malawian biological specimens will be shared with Washington only during public health emergencies and outbreaks and that no personally identifiable information passes under the agreements](#), dating the

specimen-sharing agreement to 11 February 2026 inside a five-year health package valued at US\$936 million. Malawi must supply requested specimens within seven days and gets priority access to any resulting diagnostics, vaccines or therapeutics only after meeting its own domestic needs - a clause Malawian health advocates call a major limitation. The instrument's own text remains withheld and in litigation, so what is now on the record is the shape of the deal and both governments' account of it, not its terms.

Regional collaboration

Regional work was two conversations. The minister [urged the regional bloc to target artificial-intelligence investment at a Lilongwe workshop](#), and a delegation [visited Accra to discuss digital-government cooperation with Ghana](#). Neither carries a memorandum, funding figure or timetable.

Standards

On 3 August the copyright society's blank media levy distribution was reported to rest on records submitted by licensed disc-burning centres rather than on digital consumption, with a proposal to key distribution to digital consumption voted down at an annual general meeting.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

A [four-day regional consultation on artificial intelligence and digital inclusion opened in Lilongwe on 19 August](#) under ministerial patronage, gathering public, private, academic and civil-society input. It is the fourth consultative event of the window and, like the three before it, has produced no output document.

Finance

New investments

The largest digital programme on the books came under review. The World Bank [opened a five-day implementation support mission on Malawi's US\\$150 million Digital Acceleration Project](#). Against it sits an estimate of what the reform agenda is worth: [about 1.1 trillion kwacha, some US\\$634 million, in economic value projected from targeted digital reforms](#). A projection and a mission are not results; the record held carries no disbursement figure and no delivered output against either. A consultation in Blantyre on 3 September then [put the project's second phase at US\\$35 million to US\\$75 million over a six-year implementation, covering more than 500 public-sector institutions and more than 2,000 schools](#) — the first sizing of the next tranche on record, and no commitment or approval date is stated for it. The same account carries the US\$150 million programme total that the Bank's own [appraisal puts at US\\$90 million](#), and nothing on file reconciles the two.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The communications regulator found both mobile operators in breach of the tariff-notice requirement on 17 July 2026, for failing to publish approved tariff changes seven days ahead; [both agreed to credit affected customers with bundles equal to the price difference and to show compliance by 31 July](#). The approved increase stands.

The ICT minister told Parliament that [additional mobile operator licences are under consideration and that the President had authorised the ministry to find an investor, with spectrum licence fees cut by 50% against the 20% the regulator announced in June 2025](#). No bid timetable, licence terms or spectrum allocation was stated.

The gap the licensing round is meant to close acquired figures in August. An industry association report published ahead of its Malawi summit on 20 August puts fourth-generation coverage at 87% of the population against mobile-internet penetration of 12.5%, with mobile-money adoption described as near universal, and scores Malawi 36 of 100 on its digital nations and society index and 55 of 100 on policy and regulation. These are the association's own figures; no official national subscriber and coverage series is held.

The operator's annual report puts network infrastructure investment at MK30.87bn in 2025, mainly modernisation, 4G site expansion and 5G; the US\$31m the same operator stated in August carried no period and is not reconciled with it.

An independent tower company said it had built 233 sites in 2026, 40% of them in remote rural areas, with 55 more due by early October, 28 of them rural, at a meeting where the regulator urged lower-cost infrastructure for underserved communities. The figures are the company's own.

Data Storage

The revenue authority's own resilience improved on donor money. Its World Bank-funded secondary data centre and uninterruptible power supply upgrades are reported as improving service continuity, cutting queues and improving customs-duty accuracy at border posts and the international airport, under a six-year, US\$150m regional trade and connectivity project running to 2027. The financing commitment date is not stated in the record held, and no capacity, location or availability figure is given for the facility.

The second operator reached its third data centre by purchase. It bought another company's Tier III facility at Kanengo for K12bn, about US\$6.9m, to join with its Limbe site as one cloud, three months after the build it announced was due.

Energy

The generator's own account of 22 August records reduced hydropower generation across several stations with remediation timelines running on. It follows the commissioning in July of the country's first standalone utility-scale battery storage system, 20 megawatts and 40 megawatt-hours at Kanengo, returning about 100 megawatts of previously curtailed renewable capacity to use. Storage was added in the same quarter generation fell.

Cybersecurity

The month's cybersecurity item is a loss rather than a control. The state oil company was defrauded of K700m after attackers hijacked email from its Mozambican fuel-handling contractor and supplied false banking details, instructing its bank on 29 April 2026 to wire US\$403,605 to a fraudulent account; the fraud surfaced two weeks later when the genuine contractor demanded payment, and was confirmed publicly on 24 August 2026. The company attributes the control weaknesses to the government-to-government fuel procurement model being introduced before operational and cybersecurity procedures were in place. No regulator finding, prosecution or recovery is on file.

The regulator put its own name to the methods a week later. It issued a public alert on rising digital fraud against mobile money and digital financial services, naming fake social cash transfer messages demanding a payment before assistance, failed-payment pretexts redirecting money to a second number, spoofed transaction alerts, fake competition prizes and takeovers of messaging accounts used to solicit money from contacts, and stating that bodies running social cash transfer programmes do not use ordinary messaging to request money from beneficiaries. The alert carries no incident count, loss figure or enforcement action, so the regulator is on record about the methods and not about their scale.

The regulator's own monitoring system came back under scrutiny. It [installed a system to watch misinformation on Facebook, X and LinkedIn in January 2025 under a US\\$1.5m contract awarded 15 days earlier, eight months before the election, and civil-society letters, a presidency appeal and a rights-commission inspection that was abandoned left it running](#). No audit, retention rule or oversight body is published.

The regulator then gave the fraud a source: [prisoners are behind up to 90 per cent of reported mobile-money scams](#), on its own figure, which leaves open how inmates reach handsets and networks at all.

DPI

Data Exchange

On 5 August the revenue authority signed an arrangement with its South African counterpart for real-time customs data exchange, with no go-live date and no published purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms ([signing account](#)).

Two days later the South African side notified the update from its end, [publishing the arrangement for automatic exchange of customs information together with a draft rule amendment](#). The rule is still in draft and the go-live date is still unstated.

Digital Identity and CRVS

The registration bureau reported on 13 July 2026 that more than 13.5 million people hold a national digital identity, with over 150,000 enrolled between April and June, 53% of them women ([registration bureau](#)). On 6 July it [set the forthcoming mobile credential's launch for September 2026](#), and on 5 August a separate distributed-ledger wallet was stated to be in pilot; neither announcement names the other.

Using the system got more expensive. The bureau [raised fees for national identity card replacement, electronic know-your-customer verification, civil registration and marriage services](#) under the National Registration (Amendment) Regulations 2026, gazetted on 31 July. The fee levels and their previous values are not in the record held, so the size of the increase is not established. The charge for electronic know-your-customer verification is a charge on third parties for using the identity system, levied in the month the bureau reported approaching universal coverage.

The wallet has a date. The registration bureau [set its national launch for 16 September, International Identity Day, carrying a digital ID with the card's validity, plus birth and marriage certificates, liveness checks and the physical card still valid](#).

The mobile credential launched on schedule. [The Nzika wallet went live in Lilongwe on 16 September](#), and at the launch the minister directed that national ID cards be issued without expiry dates from that day, ending the renewal regime that had left about two million cards expired.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 25 July the central bank's expected banknote replacement cost for 2026 was reported at MWK 69.8bn against MWK 50.6bn in 2025, with an economists' association president naming government levies on digital money transfers as a reason cash use persists.

Two things moved in the regional rails above it. The regional clearing house [published the scheme rulebook for instant low-cost cross-border retail payments, with a gender audit and strategy to 2030 drawn from research along the corridor with Zambia](#), giving the platform operational and governance rules it lacked. Separately a commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards in nine African markets including Malawi on 19 August](#); the merchant count is given for the nine together and not for Malawi.

The same report gives the mobile-money platform its first published revenue line: [MK51.93bn in 2025, up 77 per cent, on a stated base of more than 140,000 active agents](#).

Registries

The land register was reviewed at the centre and extended at the edges. The ministry was [reviewing electronic workflows and designing procedures for transactions still on paper](#), which is what is done when a system is in service and not working as intended, while a March mission had [trained 647 district land officers and delivered over 400 computers, 100 printers and four satellite positioning units](#). No parcel count or coverage figure is published at either end.

Sectoral management information systems

Two internal systems are close to the point where they carry real work. The automated human resource and payroll management platform [is in pilot ahead of government-wide rollout](#), and the Labour Market Information System [reached the final stage before launch after a technical workshop in mid-August](#). Neither carries a go-live date, a coverage figure or a data-source list.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A paper process is being scoped out of existence. The partnership commission and the e-government department [are specifying a web-based auctions platform carrying electronic bid submission, automated ranking, bidder anonymity and digital publication of results](#), with requirements gathered at Blantyre under a World Bank-funded project. No cost, go-live date or auction volume is stated.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The spending dashboard is running and its address is not on the record. The ministry [stated the real-time constituency development fund dashboard's coverage and its complaints channel](#), at the same event that disclosed councils receiving clean audit opinions falling to 18 in 2024/25 from 22 the year before. No address for the dashboard is established in anything the repository holds, so a transparency instrument published against a falling audit record cannot itself be inspected.

Rural digital data capture

The university [ran two days of computer-skills training for 75 police officers](#) on 13 August. It follows the budget statement's [requirement that police fees be paid cashlessly from 1 April 2026](#), and neither reaches a station: the crime management system is still at pilot, and no station count or deployment outside headquarters is on file.

Technology

AI

The artificial-intelligence strategy is being argued over before it is adopted. A commentary [urged that a verification standard be settled before any scaling into public services](#), following regional consultations. No adopted strategy text has been located, so what is in public debate is a direction rather than a document, and the verification question it raises has nothing yet to attach to.

Capacity

Training and skills

An operator's school programme reports [36 schools connected with a further nine scheduled in 2026, laboratories equipped with smart televisions and tablets, 12 local e-learning sites zero-rated, and more than 32,000 learners and over 900 teachers benefiting directly](#). All the figures are the company's own; the [continental partnership behind it is worth US\\$57m and targets 5,000 schools across 13 countries by 2027](#). The same foundation's scholarship arm named its [first 25 beneficiaries on 18 August, drawn from 17 districts and taking eight programmes at the science and technology university, computer systems and cyber security among them](#) — the places announced at the January launch, filled seven months later. No continuation beyond the one cohort is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

The first usable figure for how many Malawians are online came from the operators' own trade association rather than from the state. Its report [puts 80% of the population offline despite 87% 4G population coverage, and estimates MWK 1.1 trillion of economic value and 490,000 jobs by 2030 from closing the usage gap](#), setting out six policy priorities for the government and the regulator. The gap it identifies is usage and not coverage, which is a finding the repository had no measurement for; the value estimate is modelled by an interested party, and among the six asks is cutting the mobile-service taxes its members pay. Against it stands [a presidential target of 80% internet usage by 2026](#) that has never had a published baseline.

Digital divides

The universal service fund is in operation and funded from the regulator's annual budget allocation, and its [director general stated existing funding levels remain insufficient to meet the country's connectivity needs](#). A school connectivity project runs under it and the secondary-school skills work above is stated to draw on it. No income, balance or disbursement figure is held for any year, and the repository holds no regulator annual report or fund account at all.

Data

National statistics

The statistical office and the communications regulator [put a Fourth National ICT Survey into the field from August to October across all districts, including the refugee camp at Dzaleka](#), covering mobile and computer ownership, internet access, digital financial services, e-commerce and cybersecurity awareness. No publication date for the results is stated, which is the part that decides whether it informs anything.

Open data

What the right of access yields was measured for the first time. A newspaper investigation found that [65 per cent of 30 respondents received no answer to an information request inside the statutory 15-day period and 46.7 per cent gave up, with non-response the most cited reason a request failed](#), and its own requests to ten public institutions — among them the Anti-Corruption Bureau, two ministries, the police and the revenue authority — produced the information in no case. The human rights commission's access-to-information unit says it can only make recommendations. It is one publication's survey rather than an official series, and no state figure exists to set beside it.

Geopolitics

EU activities

The European Union [launched a EUR 143 million annual action plan for Malawi on 21 August](#), four months after the [fourth partnership dialogue covered new gateway investments](#). Neither account states a digital or data-governance component of its own, so what the money buys in this sector is not knowable from the record - which is a different problem from the money not existing.

India activities

India enters the record as a destination rather than a donor. Officials from the digital and ICT sector and line ministries [joined delegations from Ethiopia, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and Zambia and the African Union Commission on a south-south learning mission hosted by the United Nations Development Programme](#), studying India's digital public infrastructure and the institutions that built it; [the state government of Karnataka received them in Bengaluru on 1 September](#). No agreement, financing, technology transfer or follow-on commitment is named on either side.

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